

Cardiac Rhythm First Look

A safe rhythm-study sequence: client first, then rate, regularity, waves, intervals, and pattern.

Six-step strip scan - Assess the client and pulse. - Estimate rate. - Check regularity. - Look for P waves. - Measure PR and QRS. - Name the pattern only after the evidence.	High-priority clues - No pulse changes the response completely. - New chest pain, hypotension, altered mental status, shock, or severe dyspnea signal instability. - Artifact can imitate a lethal rhythm; check leads and client without delaying emergency response.
Memory line - Treat the client, not the monitor. - A rhythm name is not a complete assessment. - Follow current resuscitation training and facility algorithms.	

Reviewed 2026-07-13 - Source: National Council of State Boards of Nursing - <https://www.ncsbn.org/publications/2026-nclex-pn-test-plan>
Study aid only. Verify current references, instructor guidance, scope, orders, and facility policy.